made a major presentation with his take on the state of global mining viewed from Australia and the Pacific region. The general consensus of the conference delegates was that big mining companies were following a common strategy in both the Global North and Global South. This is the world in which Vale is excelling, far from the image it projects of South–South solidarity and a pillar of the national economy in Brazil.

The first characteristic common to big mining companies today is a strong desire for no third-party, i.e. union, intervention, with companies going out of their way to ignore unions. In Australia the mining union has waged – and won – a fight against Rio Tinto's push for individual contracts, but, even so, Rio Tinto has succeeded in union-busting in Australia's iron mines.

Vale's labour relations epitomise this anti-union stance. The actions during Roger Agnelli's presidency to reduce the unions' role in its Canadian operations have continued under Murilo Ferreira, despite Ferreira's protestation to the contrary. In June 2012 Ferreira gave a lengthy interview to the Brazilian business journal *América Economia* to mark his first year as CEO of Vale. When queried about the troubled relationship with the Vale union in Canada, and whether it was 'possible to seek a rapprochement with the opposition', his reply was: 'I found a very tense situation with the union when I arrived in Canada. I had lived for two and a half years in that country when I was Vale executive director. At that time I had an extraordinarily good relationship with the union. Upon returning to Vale as president I met with trade unionists and hope to do so again shortly. Where I go, I talk to them. I am planning to go to Canada to talk to the union in July, at which time I hope to see my union friends again' (*América Economia* 2012).

Ferreira's fine words about 'union friends' in Canada were somewhat belied by the words of Myles Sullivan, a USW staff member interviewed for the same article when he was in Brazil for the Vale Annual General Meeting and the launch of the Vale Unsustainability Report (AV 2012). Sullivan said at the time: 'For the situation to improve, Vale has to recognise and respect the USW as the bargaining agent of the employees whom we represent. Our members who carry out the work know what creates the best conditions for the work environment. If Vale stopped working against us and, on the contrary, supported us, it could benefit tremendously' (*América Economia* 2012).

Ferreira's self-congratulatory stance is even more problematic when it is juxtaposed with Sudbury local union president Rick Bertrand's memory of his first meeting with him. This came about after several Ferreira visits to Sudbury as CEO during which there was no union contact whatsoever. Bertrand opened